

Useful resources



unbarrier me

supporting School Business Leaders with technology.

reducing cognitive load, protecting time, and making the day more manageable.

School Business Leaders don't just manage workload – they manage constant switching, interruption, and responsibility.

the challenge isn't just time. it's the cognitive load of holding everything at once. the tools already exist in most school ecosystems. the shift is using them to reduce friction, not add more.

quick wins (start this week).

- block 30 minutes of focus time
- turn off non-essential notifications
- use AI to draft one task
- create one reusable template
- move one process into a form
- replace one meeting with an update
- capture tasks in one place

creating boundaries and protecting your time.

Digital

- turn off non-essential notifications
- use "Do Not Disturb"
- schedule emails

Personal

- label protected time clearly
- be unavailable when needed

cognitive load – why the day feels so full

this role requires you to:

- switch between finance, HR, and estates
- respond to issues as they arise
- hold multiple decisions in your head

what actually helps:

- stop using your inbox as your to-do list
- use [Microsoft To Do](#) or [Google Tasks](#) (taggable, shareable, collaborative)
- refine and organise using [Copilot](#) or [Gemini](#)
- build a simple bank of reusable emails, reports, and processes

reduce the load - use what you've got

most pressure isn't the task, it's the thinking behind it.

reduce cognitive load by:

- automating what repeats
- filtering what arrives
- standardising what you decide

automate

filter

standardise

Try ([Power Automate](#) / [Apps Script](#))

email - the biggest hidden drain

most SBLs are managing their day through their inbox. that's where decision fatigue builds fastest.

what to change:

use built in AI to:

- summarise threads
- draft replies
- extract key actions

Use rules and filters to:

- auto-label (Finance / HR / Safeguarding)
- reduce noise
- prioritise what matters

Useful resources

a tool worth exploring:

NotebookLM - Google NotebookLM

there are a lot of AI tools. most add noise. this one is different.

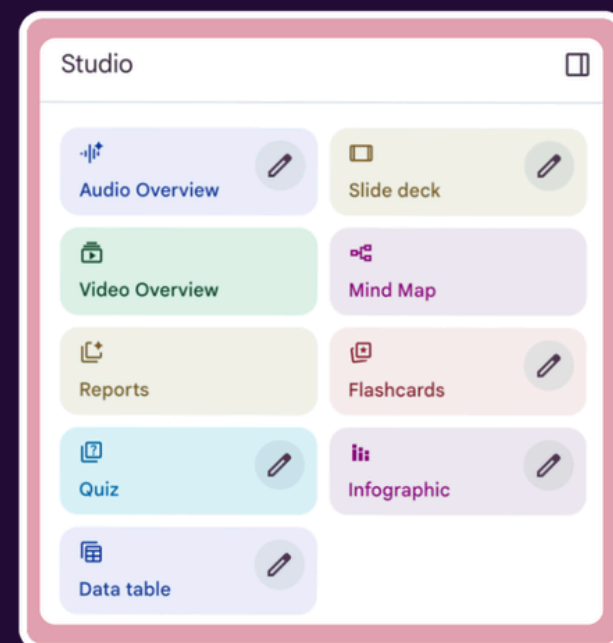
what it actually does

NotebookLM helps you work with your own materials:

- ask questions
- summarise
- extract actions
- create usable outputs

what you can bring into it

- policies and internal documents
- meeting notes or transcripts
- webpages (DfE guidance, frameworks)
- YouTube videos (briefings, training)



what this looks like in practice

meetings → upload notes or transcripts → extract decisions and actions

policy writing → upload policies + guidance → identify changes and rewrite

use safely in schools

use for:

- policies and general documents
- training
- non-sensitive materials

do not upload:

- EHCPs
- safeguarding records
- personal data

stay in your ecosystem

you don't need more tools — just better use of what you already have.

from one set of documents, you can generate summaries, reports, slide decks, and visual outputs — reducing the need to re-read and restructure information manually.

Microsoft 365

- focus Time → protected, interruption-free work
- quiet Time → no after-hours notifications
- Weekly Insights → see where your time goes
- copilot → draft, summarise, capture actions

Google Workspace

- calendar focus time → protect key work
- gemini → draft, summarise, and question
- shared docs → collaborate without email chains
- Keep → quick capture linked to your workflow



“It’s not just the workload – it’s the constant switching, interruption, and responsibility. The real pressure is the mental load that builds throughout the day. The biggest shift comes from reducing that load and creating space to think.”



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